

Bullseye Customer one-liner DIY guide

Activity 2 of 9: The searchable sentence

What you're building: Several one-liners for your Bullseye Customer and one you agree to start with, specific enough to build your full hypothesis from.

- *People:* 3–10 (the team closest to the customer)
- *Materials:* This guide + whiteboard software or analog supplies
- *Time:* 60–80 min

What the one-liner looks like

Five components in a single sentence:

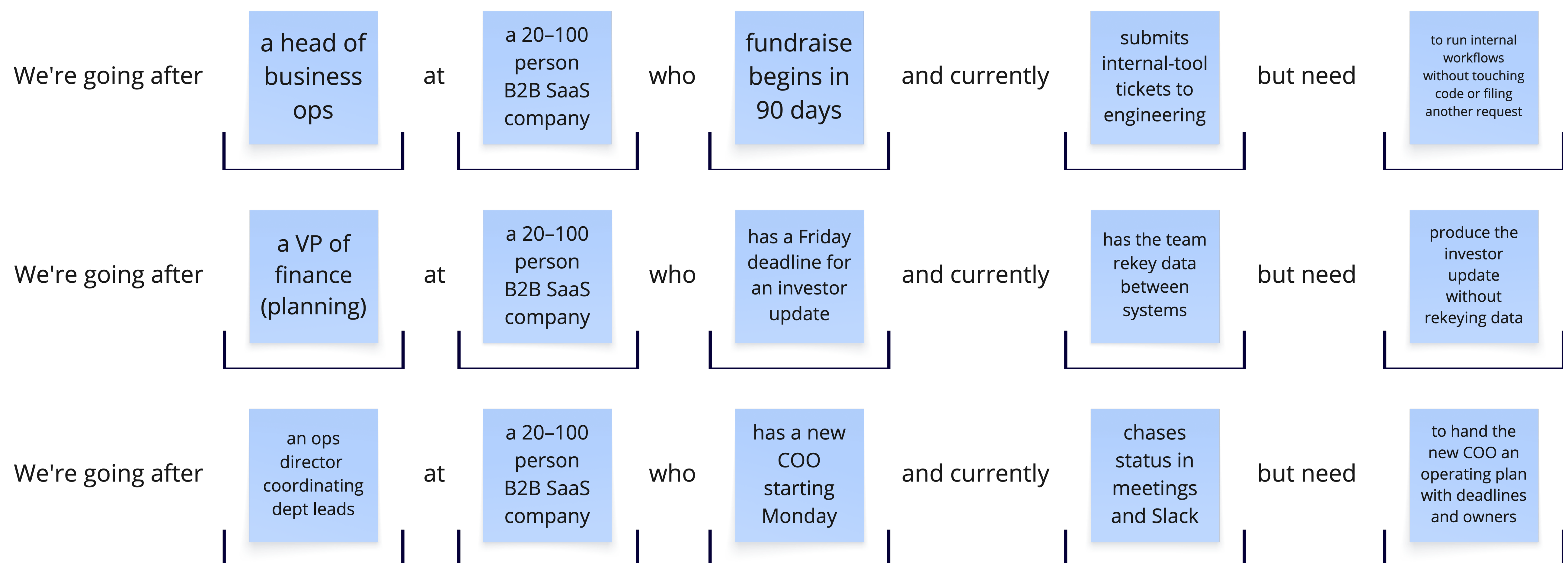


- Specific role: the person in a specific situation, not a demographic
- Specific place: company type, size, or stage
- Trigger: the moment that made this urgent, not just annoying
- Inadequate solution: what they're doing instead right now, the status quo
- Outcome: what better/done looks like for them

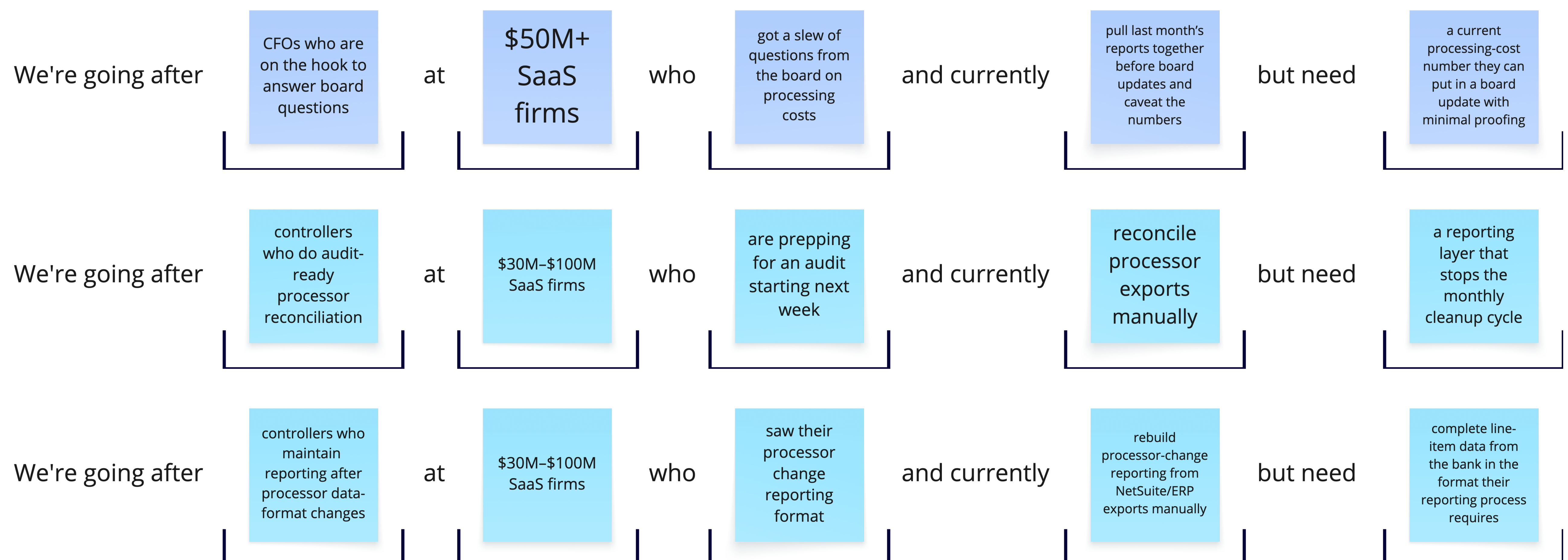
The test: Could you write a screening question directly from your one-liner without adding more detail? Could you name what you'd hear in the first couple minutes that tells you you're talking to the wrong person? If not, you're still hedging. What's ultimately picked as the one-liner is the input to your hypothesis canvas, activity 3.

Bullseye Customer one-liner: examples

Here's a set of one-liners completed with a seed-stage ops tooling startup preparing to raise. Same place (read: company context), but three different roles, triggers, current situations, and outcomes:



And another set done with a bank-integrated fintech company. The team started with CFOs at \$50M+ SaaS firms (who felt the fee pain); then we learned through interviews that controllers at \$30M–\$100M firms carried more of the burden:



Note: If a sticky names a category benefit (“visibility”), a problem (“broken data”), or a mechanism (“via dashboards”), keep tightening until it describes what the customer is doing now and what “better” would do for them.

Bullseye Customer one-liner: exercise

THE EXERCISE (60–80 min)

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Round 1: Group interview (30 min)

This is a conversation, not a survey. One person facilitates, keeps it moving. Everyone else listens, adds context, reframes, pushes back. One person speaks at a time. One thought per sticky note; don't editorialize, just get it down.

A few questions to get the conversation going:

- Who feels this problem most acutely — what's their role and what does their day look like when it's bad? When it's good?
- Then, who looks like that person but isn't the one? What makes them different?
While this won't be an explicit part of the one-liner, it's crucial for the hypothesis and it'll sharpen who your Bullseye is. A bit like asking what you don't want to have for dinner out.
- At what stage or company size does this become urgent, not just something they can deal with later? Any other details about the place?
- Have they hit that moment where they went from "we should fix this" to "we must fix this now"?
- What are they actually doing instead of fixing it right now? What's their workaround? Not what they wish they were doing — what they're actually doing?
- What does done or better look like for them? What does it feel like?

By the end of this round, you'll have a stack of sticky notes — virtual or actual — this is a catalog of what your team believes right now. It won't line up, some of it will conflict and that's useful data. Ask why, work it out together, but don't dwell.

Bullseye Customer one-liner: exercise

THE EXERCISE (60–80 min) *cont.*

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Round 2: Narrowing (10 min)

Sort your sticky notes into six categories: who they are, who they aren't, where, why now, what they do today, and what better looks like. Then, narrow. And be more specific than you think. Examples:

- "Product managers" → "VP of Product at Series B SaaS who ships monthly"
- "They're frustrated" → "Rebuilds the same spreadsheet for a report every Monday"
- "They need visibility" → "A pipeline number they'd put on a board slide without checking five other places"

For each sticky note, ask: what's behind this? So what? Why does it matter now (read: not six mos ago)? The intention is to get to a tighter set of characteristics specific enough to construct the one-liner, which is next.

Round 3: Constructing the one-liner (20 min)

Use your sharpened notes to fill in the formula. It'll feel clumsy at first but after you do the first one, the next ones will come easier. Now write several versions, they can have different roles, triggers, and outcomes. Maybe they repeat an element or two with a slight variation. More is better and when the flow starts to slow, write just a few more.

Two main things to watch for:

- Disagreement. If the team has 2-3 different flavors, different takes of the same customer, that's something to dig into — not paper over. Talk them out.
- Evidence over intent. A trigger is the event that made the problem urgent. The inadequate solution is what they're doing now, probably not happy about it. Keep those separate: "the audit starts next month" is a trigger; "they've been using spreadsheets for 18 months" is an inadequate solution.

Bullseye Customer one-liner: exercise

THE EXERCISE (60–80 min) *cont.*

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Round 4: AI & dot vote (10 min)

Take a break. Survey everything you've made. Now it's time to use AI to broaden and fine-tune your work. This isn't a shortcut. Use this prompt — paste it into whatever product/model you're working with, adding in your one-liners. Fold in a few sentences about your product plus who you think you're currently building for:

“ We just completed an exercise to identify our Bullseye Customer with a series of one-liners. Our goal is to identify a specific person we can recruit, interview, learn from, and test our assumptions with, something like: We're going after specific role at specific place who trigger and currently inadequate solution but need outcome.

Calibrate on this first: a trigger is a datable event, not a state. “Their audit starts next month” is an event — something happened on a date. “They're overwhelmed” is a state — it names how they feel, not what changed. Judge every trigger against that line. Here are our one-liners: [paste your one-liners here]

Here's a short description of our product and what we currently believe about our customer: [paste here]

For each one-liner, return four things: (1) Trigger — event or state? If it's a state, don't rewrite it. Name it as a state, say what kind (a feeling or a standing condition), and ask us one question: what recent event put this person here? Leave us to answer. (2) Inadequate solution — does it name something they're actually doing, or does it read like an assumption? Say which. (3) Outcome — specific enough to write a screening question from, or still a category (“visibility,” “efficiency,” “scale”)? Say which. (4) Exclusion — from this one-liner alone, could you name someone adjacent who'd be screened out? If not, say what's missing.

Be brief, don't select a winner, don't invent new customer segments, and don't add detail we didn't provide. Flag where language is still hedging.

Bullseye Customer one-liner: exercise

THE EXERCISE (60–80 min) *cont.*

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Round 4: AI & dot vote (10 min) *cont.*

With this, you're looking for places to be more narrow in the language you already have, not validation. Some of what comes back will sharpen a trigger or expose a generic outcome. Some of it will miss altogether, your team makes the call. Remember, even the newest models can be extremely sycophantic.

Tighten the one-liners, keep them all, then dot vote. Each person gets four dots/votes. Stack all of them on one one-liner or spread them around — this is your team picking one to start with.

In closing

In this activity, most teams will have a few moments where the conversation stalls. This usually happens because the team is too close to the answer. Someone's been thinking about something for months, someone else assumes everyone agrees with them, and no one's ever actually said it out loud.

This intends to surface those moments. When you hit a bumpy spot, that's not a failure; that's the process. An outside facilitator doesn't make the exercise smoother, but they might make it easier to stay honest when it gets uncomfortable.

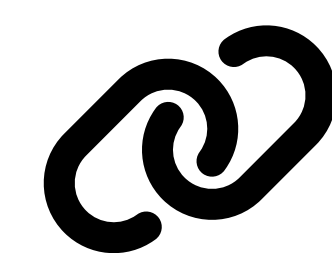
Remember, the goal is to agree on the customer you'll recruit first. The others aren't unimportant — they could be your second, third, fourth, etc. hypotheses. Keep them all.

The one-liner you've just staked goes straight into the hypothesis canvas (the 3rd activity), that's where you'll pressure-test eight specific surface areas.

Here's where we could go from here

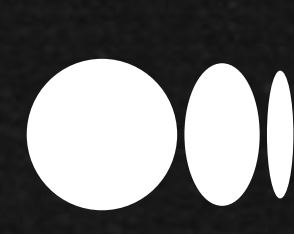
You've just done something that most teams skip entirely, good work.

The next step is the hypothesis canvas — activity 3. The one-liner is activity 2 of 9 in the Bullseye Customer Sprint, a process that takes most teams about four weeks and ends with real customer evidence and a direction everyone can stand behind.



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Doing the whole sprint isn't the right next step for everyone, let's talk. Which isn't to pose a pitch dressed up in a discovery call's clothing; just a look at where you are and what you need most.



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